

CHAPTER 11

Grassroots Democracy – Part 2: Local Government in Rural Areas

NCERT Exercise Solutions

The Big Questions	3 Q
Think About It · Gram Panchayat	1 Q
Let's Explore · Child-Friendly Panchayat Initiative	1 Q
Think About It · Panchayat Samiti and Zila Parishad	1 Q
Let's Explore · Panchayat Samiti and Zila Parishad	2 Q
The Arthaśhāstra	1 Q
Questions, activities and projects	4 Q

✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

Independent study aid by Beginers Point. Not an official NCERT publication.

The Big Questions

1 What are Panchayati Raj institutions?

✔ ANSWER

Panchayati Raj is the system of **local self-government in rural areas**. A 'Panchayat' means a village council.

It works at **three levels (three-tier system)**:

- **Village level:** Gram Panchayat
- **Block level:** Panchayat Samiti (Mandal Parishad / Block Panchayat)
- **District level:** Zila Parishad (District Panchayat)

2 What are their functions?

✔ ANSWER

- Solve local problems and plan **development** of the village and area.
- Look after agriculture, housing, **roads**, **water resources**, **education**, **health care**, social welfare and cultural activities.
- Make sure the benefits of **government schemes** reach the grassroots (e.g. Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana for all-weather roads).

- The Panchayat Samiti links Gram Panchayats with the Zila Parishad: it collects their development plans and presents them at the district or State level, which helps get funds.

3 **Why are they important in governance and democracy?**

✔ ANSWER

- They bring governance **closer to the people**, so villagers need not run to the State or national capital for every issue.
- People **take part directly** (in the Gram Sabha) and through **elected representatives** — this is self-government.
- Special rules help **disadvantaged sections** be heard, and **one-third of the seats are reserved for women**.
- Even children can take part through Bal Sabhas and Bal Panchayats.

🤔 Think About It · Gram Panchayat

? **The Patwari keeps maps that are generations old. How do you think can these old maps be helpful for us? Can they tell us something about the past and the present?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- They show who owned which land, so they help **settle land disputes**.

- They show old fields, ponds, wells, forests, paths and village boundaries.
- By comparing them with today's land, we learn **how the village has changed** — e.g. ponds filled up, new houses and roads built, forests cut.

⭐ Let's Explore · Child-Friendly Panchayat Initiative

? As a class activity, let four or five students form a Bal Panchayat and the rest of the class imagine they are the villagers. What issues will the Gram Sabha discuss? What challenges could it encounter? What solutions will it propose?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Issues: children dropping out of school, child labour, no clean toilets or drinking water in school, poor mid-day meals, unsafe roads, no playground.

Challenges: parents may not agree, there may be little money, adults may not listen to children.

Solutions: meet parents to send children back to school; ask the Gram Panchayat to build toilets, a boundary wall and a kitchen; plant trees; hold a cleanliness drive; ask for a zebra crossing near the school.

🤔 Think About It · Panchayat Samiti and Zila Parishad

? **Why do you think it is important for the government to pay more attention to the needs and problems of the disadvantaged sections of society?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Disadvantaged people often have **less money, education and power**, so their voices are not easily heard.
- Without extra help they may be left behind; special attention gives them **equal chances**.
- In a democracy the government must work for **everyone**; when all sections progress, the whole village and country progress.

⭐ Let's Explore · Panchayat Samiti and Zila Parishad

1 **What similarities and differences do you notice between the governance system at the Central level and at the Panchayat level? (Hint: refer back to Chapter 10 if required.)**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Similarities:

- Both are **democratic**: members are elected by the people.
- Both make decisions and plans and spend public money for the people's welfare.

Differences:

Central level	Panchayat level
Governs the whole country	Governs a village, block or district
People take part mainly through elected representatives (MPs)	People also take part **directly** in the Gram Sabha
Has three organs: legislature, executive, judiciary	Has three tiers: Gram Panchayat, Panchayat Samiti, Zila Parishad
Deals with national issues (defence, foreign affairs etc.)	Deals with local issues (roads, water, schools)

2 **If you get an opportunity to meet a few Panchayat members, what questions would you like to ask them? Create a questionnaire, meet some Gram Panchayat members (or invite them to school), ask the questions and write a short report.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample questionnaire:

- How were you elected, and for how many years?
- How often does the Gram Sabha meet? Do women and young people attend?
- What are the biggest problems of our village?
- Where does the Panchayat get its money from?

- Which government schemes have reached our village?
- What has the Panchayat done for schools and children?

Report: write the date, whom you met, their answers in short points, and what you learnt.

⭐ The Arthaśhāstra

? **Kauṭilya: "The king shall establish a sangrahaṇa (a sub-district head quarters) for every 10 villages; a kārvaṭika (district headquarters) for every 100 villages; a droṇamukha for every 400 villages; and a sthānīya (provincial headquarters) for every 800 villages."**

In today's language, what are the names we would give these four categories? Is it not amazing that a similar structure was thought of so long ago?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Ancient name	Today's name (nearest)
Sangrahaṇa (10 villages)	Block / tehsil
Kārvaṭika (100 villages)	District
Droṇamukha (400 villages)	Division (group of districts)
Sthānīya (800 villages)	Province / State capital

Yes, it is amazing: about **2,300 years ago** Kauṭilya planned administration level by level, from villages upward — much like our three-tier system today.

? Questions, activities and projects

1 **Test yourself — without looking at the text above, can you name the three tiers of the Panchayati Raj system? What are the key functions of each of the three tiers?**

✔ ANSWER

- **Gram Panchayat (village level):** elected by the Gram Sabha, headed by the Sarpanch/Pradhan; looks after local needs like water, village roads, school, sanitation; helped by the Panchayat Secretary (meetings, records) and the Patwari (land records).
- **Panchayat Samiti (block level):** link between Gram Panchayats and Zila Parishad; coordinates the Gram Panchayats and collects their development plans.
- **Zila Parishad (district level):** plans development for the whole district and presents plans at the State level; helps get funds for projects and schemes.

2 **Write a letter to the Sarpanch regarding the issue of plastic bags lying on the roadside in**

the village.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

To

The Sarpanch,

Gram Panchayat, Lakshmanpur

Date: _____

Subject: Plastic bags lying on the roadside

Respected Sir/Madam,

I am a student of Class 6 in our village school. Many plastic bags are lying on the roadsides of our village. They make the village dirty, block drains, and cows eat them and fall ill.

I request you to arrange regular cleaning, put dustbins at main places, and ask shopkeepers and villagers not to use plastic bags. We students will help in a cleanliness drive.

Thank you.

Yours faithfully,

(Name), Class 6

3 **In your view, what type of person should be a Gram Panchayat member?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

A Gram Panchayat member should be:

- **honest** and fair to everyone, rich or poor;
- someone who **listens** to all villagers, including women, children and disadvantaged people;

- hard-working and wanting the **development** of the village;
- able to understand village problems and government schemes;
- willing to work together with others.

4 **Your village school is next to a highway and students find it difficult to cross the road. What are the options to solve this issue? Which institutions in the Panchayati Raj can help you? What can the students do?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Options: a zebra crossing, speed breakers, 'School Ahead – Go Slow' signboards, a traffic guard at school times, or a foot over-bridge/underpass.

Institutions: the **Gram Panchayat** first; it can take the matter to the **Panchayat Samiti** and the **Zila Parishad**, which can ask the State authorities in charge of the highway.

Students can: discuss it in the Bal Sabha/Bal Panchayat, write a letter to the Sarpanch, raise it in the Gram Sabha with parents, and cross only in groups with care.

🎉 **Chapter 11 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**